

The company chosen for analysis is Barnes & Noble located on the Rutgers College Avenue campus. The primary contact is Robert Mann, the store manager. The bookstore operates with a staff of 50 employees, most of whom are Rutgers students. The store is part of the larger Barnes & Noble retail chain, which faces competition from online retailers like Amazon but has a unique position as a partner for Rutgers University, offering textbooks, university-related merchandise, and educational programs.

The primary output problem identified at the Barnes & Noble store on the Rutgers campus is ineffective customer engagement and staffing issues. Students are largely unaware of the store's full range of services, such as textbook rentals, educational programs, and university merchandise. The root cause of this problem lies in staff turnover, as the majority of employees are students who work part-time. This transient workforce lacks long-term engagement with the store, affecting their ability to build relationships with customers. Consequently, the store struggles to integrate into the university's culture and offer consistent service to students.

To gather insights into the operational challenges at the Barnes & Noble store on the Rutgers campus, a combination of primary and secondary data collection methods were utilized. Interviews were conducted with key employees to understand the internal dynamics and identify the root causes of the issues faced by the store. The first interview was with Robert Mann, the store manager, who provided insights into the management, staffing issues, and the challenges of integrating the bookstore into the university environment. Emily Huntington, a store employee, shared her perspective on job satisfaction, customer service challenges, and the awareness of store services among students. Finally, Jackson Smith, a shift lead, discussed team management, conflict resolution strategies, and the difficulties faced during peak times, especially in maintaining customer service standards.

In addition to the interviews, secondary data was gathered from reputable sources to better understand the broader context in which the bookstore operates. Research from Elite Authors (2023) and Publishers Weekly provided valuable industry insights into the trends shaping the bookselling market, particularly the shift toward online shopping and the increasing popularity of e-books and audiobooks. Data from library databases offered additional insights on how other bookstores market their services and address the challenges posed by digital media. A survey was also conducted with Rutgers students to assess their familiarity with the bookstore's services and gather feedback on their attitudes toward the store. The survey was designed to identify gaps in communication and evaluate student awareness of the various resources offered by the bookstore, such as textbook rentals, educational programs, and university merchandise.

The interview questions were structured to address key areas of concern, including how daily staffing impacts customer service, how the store has adapted to the shift toward online book sales, the steps being taken to improve communication with the Rutgers community, and the role of employee turnover in service delivery. These methods provided a comprehensive view of the challenges faced by the bookstore and informed the analysis of the output problem.

The book retail industry has faced significant challenges with the rise of e-books and online shopping. Barnes & Noble, the largest retail bookseller in the U.S., competes with major online platforms like Amazon, as well as independent authors who sell directly to consumers. While the shift to digital reading formats has impacted sales at physical bookstores, the industry remains substantial, valued at approximately \$138 billion as of 2023 (Elite Authors, 2023). However, the Barnes & Noble location at Rutgers University faces a unique set of challenges that differ from the struggles seen in other stores. One of the main issues is the lack of student

awareness about the full range of services offered at the campus bookstore. Many students only see it as a place to buy textbooks or university merchandise, missing out on other available resources. This problem is compounded by high staff turnover, as the majority of the employees are Rutgers students who work part-time and are only at the store for a limited time. This transient workforce makes it difficult to build long-term customer relationships and provide consistent service. Additionally, the bookstore's management has been struggling to integrate more fully into the campus community, which limits its relevance to students beyond its role as a textbook and merchandise retailer. These challenges highlight the need for stronger connections between the store and the Rutgers student body.

Based on the interviews which were conducted between team members and employees of Barnes and Nobles such as the Store Manager, Robert Mann, Store Employee, Emily Huntington, and Shift Lead, Jackson Smith it was evident that the themes that were present and influencing the output problems were motivation within employees as well as conflict resolution. This came to light most evidently after the interview held with Jackson Smith, a shift lead at Barnes and Nobles. He stated that employee motivation is important to the success of the team especially during busy shifts. Emily Huntington added to that when she mentioned that the positive spirits the employees need to greet customers is important to the store and based on motivation. She also stated that she noted the same issue the manager did in regard to the output problem and suggested some resolutions such as marketing strategies to reach students but has not exercised any of them. The team concluded that motivation might be a reason why she has not put her resolutions into action either. Motivating employees seems to be an essential theme when studying the success of Barnes and Nobles along with conflict resolution. In the interview with Jackson Smith he revealed that there was a need for effective conflict resolution strategies in the

company. Especially during stressful times there have been notable conflicts between employees that may be affecting motivation and the overall output problem. The team noted that positive conflict is not the issue in question but rather the conflict that creates uneasiness between the staff is what needs improvement and for this there needs to be better ways to solve the conflict. The goal for the company is to restore harmony in the workplace in order to create an environment that is more inclusive, where employees will feel valued and their voices heard.

Motivation and conflict resolution has proven to be the two most notable themes our company, Barnes and Nobles is facing in their output problem. When we refer to motivation outside of this problem it can be identified as the drive someone has towards their work and goals as well as the persistence it is carried with and within the context of our issue we see that is evident since the employees who are working for Barnes and Noble's are lacking a sense of intensity and direction into integrating the school and store. Similarly, conflict resolution can be defined as the process when two parties with competing interests resolve an issue with both interests in mind which in context of the company is also an issue since employees at Barnes and Nobles with competing interests have had trouble in reaching agreements.

Using our team's direct research from sources at the location, such as interviews with managers and direct discussions with employees, we were able to uncover evidence for the causations of the primary output problem for the organization. In particular, we were able to find evidence of the root causes for the output problem of not being able to reach the wide population of students due to their lack of awareness and little integration with the campus. Our data collection and analysis also displayed clearly the potential solutions we could implement or recommend implementation of to solve the problem. The solution of motivation came up as employees frequently mentioned being unmotivated to work due to difficulties in balancing

work, life, and school. The managers of Barnes and Noble also agreed by saying that having employees stay for long periods of time is a difficult challenge for them. As a result of these direct sayings, we were able to conclude that the core concept of motivation was necessary for the company's growth. Additionally, the core concept of conflict-resolution was present often as managers claimed to have trouble getting the awareness of their opportunities and offers to reach the student population. This conflict has been correctly identified to be a result of a lack of integration with the campus as a whole, but little is being done to resolve this conflict in order to better integrate themselves. As a result, the key concept of conflict-resolution needs to be better presented and developed in the organization to ensure its growth and the solving of this output problem.

The problems of integration into the campus and better involvement from the employees of Barnes and Noble's contribute greatly to the overall output problem for the organization. Our identified core concepts, however, if integrated properly into the organization's daily lifestyle, would greatly assist in solving these problems. These solutions were having better motivation and conflict resolution practices implemented into the company's day-to-day routine and lifestyle. We found this as even the employees felt that they were not properly integrated with Barnes and Noble's as a part of Rutgers, seeing themselves as off-campus and away from the primary school. Motivating employees to work would not only increase employee retention but would make them incorporate the bookstore and the organization as a whole into their day-to-day college life, making them feel as if the bookstore is a part of their college experience and life. As a result, their peers would follow suit and word would spread, allowing the problem of low awareness to be solved by better integrating this Barnes and Noble's location into the campus. However, motivation is only one of the potential solutions to this problem, and combining it with

another solution would greatly increase the odds of success, as well as the magnitude of success that is achieved. The solution that best accompanies motivation is better conflict-resolution skills being implemented in the workplace. While motivation is important, it is also important to understand why the company struggles to have employees be motivated in the first place. In this case, the conflict stems from the difficulty of young student employees in balancing the work, school, and social aspects of their lives. This problem can be better navigated by implementing conflict-resolution strategies to ensure employees are given a “win-win” for working, allowing them to be better motivated, and solving the problem of employee retention. Additionally, the conflict for low outreach and awareness to the students of Rutgers has been properly identified as a direct result of the poor integration of the bookstore to the overall Rutgers campus and culture. But very little is being done to properly solve the problem. Conflict-resolution skills would allow for this problem to be solved properly as the conflict has already been properly identified, but there are no efforts being made on the resolution aspect of the problem. If these skills are developed and integrated into the organization’s culture and operating style, it will allow for much greater growth and will solve the integration problem. Additionally, this could also solve other minor issues for the organization that may be present but not prioritized or simply undetected. This could also solve problems going forward by preventing them beforehand, as the newer skills would allow for future conflicts to be resolved more quickly and efficiently compared to previously. Both these conflict-resolution strategies and motivation tactics in the workplace would help solve the output problem of Barnes and Noble’s and allow them to thrive more as an organization.

The section now provides a strategic suggestion for business challenges and opportunities that surround the Barnes & Noble bookstore at College Avenue near Rutgers University. In this

regard, two strategic suggestions are being proffered that would ensure an increase in customer traffic, customer service relations, and a more competitive platform at a time when the retail space has been dominated by virtual stores. Recommendation one entails implementing an omnichannel strategy where the in-store and online store will interface. The second has to do with community event development aimed at positioning the store as the cultural spot for the Rutgers community. These recommendations are put in place to ensure growth with mitigated risks, using best practices from other organizations and considering the unique dynamics at play in this location.

The first recommendation, omnichannel strategy, will create a seamless connection between in-store and online operations of Barnes & Noble. This approach will help the company overcome some of the most daunting challenges it faces, such as declining foot traffic and competition from e-commerce giants like Amazon. This enables features such as in-store pick-up for online orders, personalized recommendations based on online browsing behavior, and integrated return policies that enhance convenience and improve the overall customer experience. This will be particularly apt for a location near a major university, where this will ensure that local students and faculty can prioritize efficiency and flexibility in their shopping experiences. As one example, a student may order a textbook online to pick up in-store between classes, or return a product bought online without hassle.

Other organizations have shown just how well this can work. For example, Target has successfully integrated its digital and physical operations with services such as "Drive Up," where customers can order items online for same-day pickup. The move has improved customer satisfaction and resulted in strong sales growth. Similarly, Best Buy leveraged physical stores as distribution centers for online orders to offer quicker deliveries and enhance logistic efficiency.

By emulating these best practices, Barnes & Noble can take advantage of the proximity to Rutgers while competing against e-commerce sites.

Despite these potential benefits, this recommendation also presents some potential drawbacks. First, technical glitches in implementation may occur, such as inventory mismatches or website outages, frustrating customers and hurting the brand's reputation. Secondly, it is costly to create an omnichannel infrastructure: the costs include investment in technology, logistics, and staff training. Though necessary for long-term success, these expenses are a huge financial commitment upfront. Third, there is an element of unintended consequence: overemphasizing digital convenience might detract from the store's traditional appeal as a place to browse, relax, and discover books, which is a key differentiator from purely digital competitors.

The second is to expand the community-oriented events in the store, positioning Barnes & Noble as a cultural hub for the Rutgers community. Events such as book clubs, author signings, poetry readings, and writing workshops will make the store a special place that students and residents alike can remember. Community-oriented programming helps this store stand out from virtual online bookstores and allows patrons to have an experience unavailable online. It also furthers the interests of the demographic of the university, so thereby it helps in the creation and perpetuation of engagement and loyalty among the population that is the students and faculty.

Community involvement has proven to be a successful way for other companies to build brand and traffic. For example, in-store events sponsored by Starbucks, such as local meetups and live music, help customers create an emotional connection. These efforts make customers feel that they belong and encourage repeat visits. Similarly, REI runs workshops and events in

the outdoors that appeal to their audience and make them a trusted brand in their community. It would also allow Barnes & Noble to learn from these and tailor its own events to the interests and needs of the Rutgers community.

This recommendation, however, has a number of disadvantages. One of the main risks is that events held within the community may not always attract a big audience, particularly during periods when students are less active, such as holidays or examination seasons. This may lead to underutilization of resources and a lesser return on investment. Events also require marketing expenses, staff effort, and event materials that can stretch the store's budget. Finally, there is the risk of unintended outcomes, such as alienating certain segments of customers if events are perceived as irrelevant, exclusionary, or poorly executed. To minimize these risks, Barnes & Noble should focus on targeted programming, while continually soliciting and utilizing feedback in refining the events offered.

The use of social proof is introduced as a means of validation of the recommendations to reduce resistance from stakeholders. The success stories of Target, Best Buy, Starbucks, and REI can be underlined to show how similar initiatives have been tried, overcome a lot of challenges, and seized opportunities. Sharing data and testimonials from such organizations will help build credibility with stakeholders that such strategies are feasible and impactful. Additionally, the principle of commitment and consistency can be used by starting with small, manageable pilot programs. For instance, it could start with hosting one or two events, or perhaps introducing only one omnichannel feature. The stakeholders would then have more incentive to scale the initiatives as they see more positive results, and naturally develop into a full implementation of those.

By applying these recommendations, Barnes & Noble on College Avenue can position itself as a vibrant and customer-centric destination, playing to both its physical strengths and its connection to the Rutgers community. This is also the essence of an omnichannel strategy: addressing practical needs for a modern, digitally savvy audience and creating meaningful, memorable experiences through community events that instill loyalty. Put together, both strategies position the store to be competitive, relevant, and valued within the Rutgers ecosystem. The costs, risks, and unplanned consequences from both projects should be measured against each other; nonetheless, the gains of those programs significantly surpass the issues, thus being a strategic investment in the successful future of the store.

Appendix

Draft of Interview Questions & Transcript:

First Interview- Follow Up With the Store Manager October 4th -

Questions:

1. What would you describe as the management philosophy at Barnes & Noble? How does this management philosophy integrate with day-to-day operations?

2. Does Barnes & Noble have programs or initiatives for developing its managers and leaders?

3. What kinds of things does Barnes & Noble do to really help build a sense of teamwork and collaboration among employees? Can you give me an example of a successful team project?.

4. What techniques do management use when dealing with different forms of conflicts that workers' teams will face and what can management use to influence worker problems so that problems will be discussed?

5. Barnes & Noble is the company whose performance Barnes & Noble employs, as well as management criteria with which success is measured:

6. What techniques ensure that customer experiences are to be enjoyed?

- Transcript:

Question 1 - Answer: At Barnes & Noble, the management philosophy is all about putting the customer first. They create a welcoming vibe and really engage with employees. This

shows up in everyday work through solid training, hands-on leadership, and lots of communication, making sure everyone is focused on keeping customers happy.

Question 2 - Answer: Absolutely! Barnes & Noble has programs to help managers grow, like mentorship and workshops. They focus on important skills like conflict resolution and team management, making sure their leaders are well-equipped to guide their teams.

Question 3 - Answer: To boost teamwork, Barnes & Noble encourages open communication and hosts team-building activities. They create a friendly environment where everyone feels included and motivated to work together.

Question 4 - Answer: A cool example is when cross-functional teams come together to organize community outreach events. This not only builds camaraderie among employees but also helps connect with customers in meaningful ways.

Question 5 - Answer: Management tackles conflicts through mediation and open discussions. They really promote an open-door policy, so employees feel safe sharing their concerns. This creates a transparent atmosphere where issues can be talked about constructively.

Question 6 - Answer: To make sure customers have a great experience, Barnes & Noble focuses on thorough training for employees, regularly asks for feedback, and gives staff the power to make decisions on the spot. This approach helps create a responsive and personal shopping experience.

Second Interview Conducted October 21st Store Employee: Emily Huntington

- Questions:

1. What do you like most about your job at Barnes & Noble?
2. How would you balance between work and other commitments?
3. Can you describe a time when you provided excellent customer service?
4. How would you manage any busy spell when crowding in the store?
5. What skills do you feel you have developed by working at Barnes & Noble that you might find helpful in the future?

- Transcript:

Question 1 - Answer: I love being surrounded by books and people who love to read just as much as I do. I love giving recommendations to customers and encouraging reading. Also, the atmosphere is very friendly, so it's fun to be there.

Question 2 - Answer: I use a planner in order to keep up with my schedule and rank my priorities, making sure to plan with my manager exactly when I am available, so I can balance my work hours with my schoolwork and social life.

Question 3 - Answer: Once, there was a customer who wanted a certain book that was out of stock. I showed initiative by first checking through our inventory system. While it wasn't available, I offered to order it for them and put it aside with a special discount. They were very grateful, and I just loved being able to help them.

Question 4 - Answer: I concentrate on being organized and prioritizing the tasks during busy times. I ask my team when needed, and communicate with them. I keep a positive attitude

and am efficient in doing things, which will help me to handle the rush without being overwhelmed.

Question 5 - Answer: I have developed great customer service skills, have learned how to work in a team, and my time management has gotten so much better. These are retail skills, but I know they will carry over with me into whatever career path I choose..

Third Interview Conducted Novemeber 1st Shift Lead: Jackson Smith -

Questions:

1. What do you consider your primary responsibilities as a shift lead?
2. How would you motivate your team on busy shifts?
3. Describe one specific situation you've encountered as a shift lead that was particularly difficult to work with and how you handled it.
4. How do you ensure the team follows company policy and procedures?
5. How will you deal with conflicts among team members?

- Transcript:

Question 1 - Answer: As a shift lead, my main responsibilities will revolve around daily operations, team members, and customer service. I organize activities, schedule staff, and resolve issues that come up on my shift to make sure everything runs without a hitch.

Question 2 - Answer: I inspire my team because I am positive and I acknowledge the effort put in by them. Encourage open communication; if things get frenetic, I inform them that

support is available. It means a lot to morale when people feel their contributions are seen and acknowledged with small wins.

Question 3 - Answer: One of the challenges was when, during one of the major book launch events, we had a particularly large crowd. I immediately began delegating responsibilities, making sure each person knew what to do. We even created a quick check-in process that would be very helpful in answering customer queries and moving the lines forward to keep customers satisfied.

Question 4 - Answer: I lead by example and reinforce continuously with others why the policies and procedures of the company are in place. I have regular team meetings where such guidelines are reviewed and ensure that feedback is provided. In case any person is not sure about a particular matter, I make them feel comfortable enough to ask questions to clarify doubts.

Question 5: Answer - Exercising Conflict Resolution: I have promptly dealt with emerging conflicts by offering a private one-on-one talk between the parties concerned. Open up a dialogue to find out what both parties are saying and attempt to get them to see common ground. I attempt to offer an environment of respect where every voice matters.

Contact Log:

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/191elrHjVOGrjuY2slEh4vilylvqxrlwMXMW97lX9Tj4/edit?gid=0#gid=0>

Individuals interviewed so far:

1. Robert Mann- Store Manager

2. Emily Huntington - Store Employee

3. Jackson Smith - Shift Lead

Bibliography

“Conflict in the Workplace: Top Tactics Every Young Adult Should Know.” *Boys & Girls Clubs of America*, 20 Nov. 2024,

www.bgca.org/news-stories/2023/October/conflict-resolution/?gad_source=1&gclid=Cj0KCQiAr7C6BhDRARIsAOUKifj8CeusZkTaF4-5WPlsMFry1k7FrbPmA-YYK1Zw8As3pHnzKyVTLcwaAqWVEALw_wcB. Accessed 2 Dec. 2024.

Herrity, Jennifer. “12 Motivation Techniques for the Workplace | Indeed.com.” *Wwww.indeed.com*, 3 Dec. 2020,

www.indeed.com/career-advice/career-development/motivation-techniques-for-the-workplace.

Knowledge Hut. “Motivation Theories - 5 Famous Motivation Theories | KnowledgeHut.”

KnowledgeHut Tutorial, 27 Feb. 2019,

www.knowledgehut.com/tutorials/project-management/motivation-theories.

Marketing, UOTP. “21 Motivational Strategies for Students.” *University of the Potomac*, 30 Aug. 2022, potomac.edu/student-motivation-ideas/.

Shonk, Katie. “5 Conflict Resolution Strategies.” *PON - Program on Negotiation at Harvard Law School*, Harvard Law School, 11 Oct. 2022,

www.pon.harvard.edu/daily/conflict-resolution/conflict-resolution-strategies/.

Tracy, Brian. *Motivation*. New York, American Management Association, 2013.

University Of Michigan. *The Journal of Conflict Resolution*. Dept. Of Journalism, University Of Michigan, Ann Arbor, Mich, 1998.

Wellable. “7 Effective Conflict Resolution Techniques in the Workplace.” *Wellable*, 22 Aug. 2023, www.wellable.co/blog/conflict-resolution-techniques-in-the-workplace/.